

Chapter Seven

What Nora Could Not Unfeel

For three days, Nora did not jump.

That should have felt like mercy.

Instead, it felt like waiting.

She moved through those days carefully, as if her life had become a room full of sleeping animals. Any sudden sound, any wrong step, any emotion too sharp might wake something.

Adam called every morning.

Maya texted every night.

Neither of them used the word normal, and Nora was grateful for that. Normal had become an insult somehow. A place everyone else still lived, but she could only visit in memory.

They built rules because Adam needed structure, because Maya needed boundaries, and because Nora needed proof that the impossible could be made survivable if they named enough pieces of it.

After a jump, Nora had to sit down.

If she felt pressure behind her eyes, she had to say something immediately.

No one would use private information from a jump unless someone was in danger.

Nora would not disappear afterward.

The rules looked reasonable when Adam wrote them down in his careful handwriting.

They looked almost silly on paper.

Four small sentences against the collapse of reality.

Still, Nora folded the page and carried it in her coat pocket.

On the fourth day, Maya's father began treatment.

Maya did not ask Nora to come.

Nora did not offer.

That restraint felt unnatural, almost violent. All morning, she moved around her apartment like a person trying not to scratch an open wound. She wanted to text Maya every five minutes. She wanted to ask which hospital, which doctor, which treatment room, whether Maya had eaten, whether her mother was with her, whether her father was scared.

Instead, she sent one message at 8:12 a.m.

Thinking of you today. No need to answer.

Maya replied almost an hour later.

Thank you. I'll text when we're done.

Nora stared at the message.

Then she put the phone face down and forced herself not to touch it.

She cleaned the kitchen.

Then the bathroom.

Then the kitchen again.

By noon, the apartment smelled sharply of lemon cleaner and nervous energy.

Her phone remained silent.

At 1:34 p.m., Adam arrived with soup.

Nora opened the door and stared at the paper bag in his hand.

"What is that?"

"Soup."

"I can see that."

“You haven’t eaten.”

“You don’t know that.”

Adam glanced past her into the apartment. His eyes moved over the spotless counter, the damp sink, the untouched coffee cup. “I know enough.”

Nora stepped aside.

He entered carefully, not with the old ease he used to have, but with the new caution all three of them had begun practicing around one another. Adam no longer touched her automatically. He asked with his eyes first. Sometimes with words.

That should have made her feel respected.

Mostly, it made her feel guilty.

He set the soup on the table and took off his coat.

“Any pressure today?” he asked.

“No.”

“Dizziness?”

“No.”

“Emotional residue?”

She gave him a tired look. “You make it sound like a medical side effect.”

“That’s because I’m trying not to call it haunting.”

Despite herself, Nora smiled.

The smile surprised them both.

For a second, something old moved between them. A familiar warmth. A small bridge.

Then Nora looked away first.

Adam unpacked the soup. Two containers. Bread wrapped in paper. A plastic spoon she did not need but appreciated because he had thought of everything.

They sat across from each other at the small round table.

The same table where Maya had eaten almond pastry from a paper bag less than a week ago.

The memory made Nora's chest ache.

Adam noticed, of course.

"She'll text," he said.

"I know."

"She said she would."

"I know."

He broke the bread in half and gave her the larger piece. "Knowing doesn't always help."

Nora looked at him.

"No," she said. "It doesn't."

They ate in quiet for a few minutes.

The soup was warm and too salty. Nora ate anyway.

Adam watched her with the expression of someone trying not to watch too closely.

She set down her spoon. "You can ask."

He blinked. "Ask what?"

"Whatever you've been wanting to ask since the church."

Adam leaned back slightly.

There it was again. That carefulness.

"I have about forty questions," he said.

“That few?”

“I narrowed them down.”

Nora almost smiled again.

Adam’s face softened, but only for a moment. Then the seriousness returned.

“When you jump,” he said, “do you feel like yourself?”

Nora looked down at her hands.

The question seemed simple until she tried to answer it.

“At first, yes. I know I’m me. I know the body isn’t mine. I panic because it isn’t mine.”

“And then?”

“Then their feelings come in.”

Adam nodded slowly.

Nora continued, “Not like hearing someone describe how they feel. More like... being placed inside the weather of them. It’s already happening when I arrive. Their fear. Their grief. Their memories. Their body. I’m still there, but I’m smaller.”

Adam’s jaw tightened. “Smaller.”

“Yes.”

“How small?”

Nora swallowed.

She thought of Anna Rose, of the name Leo beating inside her like a second heart until Nora had almost vanished beneath it.

“Sometimes almost gone.”

Adam closed his eyes briefly.

When he opened them, his expression was controlled, but Nora felt the effort behind it.

“I hate that,” he said.

“I do too.”

“No, I mean I hate that it happens to you and I can’t do anything.”

Nora looked away.

There it was.

Adam’s wound. His need to repair what hurt. His terror of standing beside pain without tools.

“You do things,” she said.

“I bring soup.”

“That counts.”

“It doesn’t feel like enough.”

“It never feels like enough to you.”

The sentence came out softly, but Adam still flinched.

Nora regretted it immediately. “I didn’t mean—”

“No,” he said. “You’re right.”

He looked toward the window.

Rain had started again, fine and quiet, tapping against the glass like fingernails.

“I keep thinking there has to be a cause,” Adam said. “Something neurological. Psychological. Some trigger pattern. Emotional proximity, maybe. Stress response. Trauma response.”

“Adam.”

“I know how it sounds.”

“It sounds like you’re trying to diagnose a miracle.”

His mouth tightened. “Is that what you think it is?”

“No.”

“What do you think it is?”

Nora looked at the rain.

“I think it’s a door,” she said. “And I think I keep falling through it.”

Neither of them spoke after that.

Then Nora’s phone buzzed.

She moved so fast the chair legs scraped against the floor.

Maya.

Done. He’s tired but okay. I’m okay too. Mostly.

Nora pressed the phone to her chest.

Relief came first.

Then the pressure.

Not behind her eyes.

In her ribs.

A sudden, intense longing to know if Maya was telling the truth.

I’m okay too. Mostly.

Mostly could mean anything. Mostly could hide a thousand things. Mostly could be mercy. Mostly could be collapse wrapped in a manageable word.

Nora’s grip tightened around the phone.

Adam saw her face change.

“Nora.”

“I’m fine.”

“You’re not.”

“I’m not jumping.”

“That’s not the only danger anymore.”

She looked up sharply.

He seemed almost sorry he had said it, but he did not take it back.

Nora placed the phone on the table.

Then pulled her hands into her lap, away from it.

Adam watched.

“Good,” he said quietly.

“Don’t sound proud of me like I’m a child.”

“I’m not.”

“You are.”

“I’m proud of you like you’re a person doing something hard.”

The anger left her too quickly.

She hated that too.

Her phone buzzed again.

Maya had sent a photo.

Nora hesitated before opening it.

Adam waited.

The photo showed Maya’s hand holding a paper cup of hospital coffee. Beside it, another hand rested on the arm of a chair. Older. Thin. An IV taped to the skin.

Maya’s father.

There was no face in the photo. Just hands. Proof without exposure.

A caption followed.

He says hospital coffee tastes like punishment.

Nora laughed.

It broke out of her unexpectedly, wet and shaky.

Adam smiled faintly.

Nora typed:

He is correct.

Then she added:

I'm glad treatment is done for today.

She stopped there.

No questions.

No demands.

No hidden attempt to make Maya prove how okay she was.

Maya replied with a heart.

Nora set the phone down again.

For a few seconds, she felt almost steady.

Then the apartment door opened.

Not physically.

Not the real door.

Something inside her opened.

A sensation like hearing a room inhale.

Nora gripped the table.

Adam sat forward. "Pressure?"

"No."

“What is it?”

“I don’t know.”

The air thickened.

The rain against the window grew louder, though outside it had not changed. Nora felt suddenly aware of every apartment around hers. The old man upstairs dragging a chair. A baby crying two floors below. A woman laughing behind the wall. Lives stacked above and beneath and beside her, separated by plaster, pipes, habit.

Then one feeling rose through all the others.

Fear.

Close.

Not Maya’s.

Not Adam’s.

Not a stranger across the city.

Close.

Nora turned toward the wall she shared with the neighboring apartment.

Adam followed her gaze.

“What?”

“Someone next door is afraid.”

The sentence sounded absurd in the quiet kitchen.

Adam stood.

“Nora, sit down.”

“I am sitting.”

“Stay sitting.”

The fear sharpened.

A muffled thud came from the neighboring apartment.

Then a voice.

Too low to understand.

Another thud.

Nora's breath caught.

Adam heard it too.

His face changed.

They stood at the same time.

"Nora," he said.

"She's scared."

"You don't know that."

"Yes, I do."

The certainty frightened her, but not as much as the fear coming through the wall.

A woman's voice rose.

"Please, just leave."

Adam went still.

Another voice answered. Male. Angry. Blurred by the wall.

Nora's vision trembled.

Not a jump.

Not yet.

But the door was there.

Open a crack.

She could feel the woman on the other side. Panic trapped behind ribs. A hand around a phone. The calculation of distance to the door. The terrible clarity of someone trying to survive the next minute.

Nora stepped toward the hallway.

Adam caught her wrist. “Wait.”

“She needs help.”

“We call emergency services.”

The woman next door cried out.

Nora pulled free.

The pressure slammed behind her eyes.

Adam swore softly. “Nora, no.”

Too late.

The kitchen stretched.

The sound of rain became a roar.

Nora reached for the table, for Adam, for anything that belonged to her.

His hand closed around hers.

For one second, she stayed.

Then the wall between apartments vanished.

She was standing in a living room she had never seen.

Her cheek burned.

Her breath came in shallow bursts.

A phone lay under the coffee table, screen cracked, call unfinished.

Not her phone.

Not her cheek.

A man stood between her and the door, breathing hard.

He was not large, but anger made him fill the room.

The woman's body trembled around Nora.

Her name came in a burst of terror.

Claire.

Twenty-nine.

Neighbor from the apartment next door.

The man stepped closer.

"Don't make me the villain," he said.

Claire's mouth opened.

Nora felt the words she wanted to say.

You already are.

But Claire said nothing.

Because Claire had learned that some truths were more dangerous when spoken aloud.

Nora's panic became something colder.

This was not grief.

This was immediate danger.

Rule three.

Private pain stayed private unless someone was in danger.

Someone was.

Claire's eyes moved to the door.

The man saw it.

“Don’t,” he said.

From far away, muffled by walls and bodies and whatever strange distance separated Nora from her own life, she heard pounding.

Adam.

“Nora!” he shouted.

No.

Not Nora.

He was at Claire’s door.

The man turned toward the sound.

Claire’s body seized its chance before Nora understood it.

She lunged for the phone beneath the coffee table.

The man grabbed her arm.

Pain flashed white.

Nora screamed inside her.

Claire screamed outside.

The front door rattled.

Adam’s voice came again, harder now. “Open the door!”

Another voice joined his.

A woman from the hall.

“What’s happening?”

The man’s grip loosened.

Not from remorse.

From witnesses.

Claire twisted free and stumbled backward into the lamp. It fell, shattering across the floor.

The sound broke something open.

The jump began to tear.

Nora felt Claire's fear, Adam's urgency outside the door, her own body somewhere beyond the wall, maybe collapsed in the kitchen, maybe still holding Adam's hand.

Too many lives.

Too much weather.

The room tilted.

The last thing Nora saw through Claire's eyes was the man stepping back, suddenly smaller under the weight of being seen.

Then Nora returned.

She came back on the kitchen floor with Adam kneeling beside her, one hand on her shoulder and the other holding his phone to his ear.

"Yes," he said into the phone. "Apartment 4B. There's a domestic disturbance. I heard screaming."

Nora gasped.

Adam looked down at her, relief flashing across his face, but he did not stop speaking to the dispatcher.

"She's conscious," he said. "No, not the woman next door. My fiancée. I need police at 4B."

From the hallway came voices.

A door opening.

A woman crying.

The man shouting something Nora could not understand.

Then another neighbor, loud and firm: “Stay back. Police are coming.”

Nora tried to sit up.

Adam pressed gently against her shoulder. “Stay down.”

“Claire,” she whispered.

Adam froze.

“You know her name?”

Nora nodded.

His face tightened, but he did not ask.

Not yet.

The rules had changed again.

They both knew it.

The jumps were not only showing Nora grief now.

They could put her inside danger while danger was still happening.

Sirens rose in the distance.

Nora lay on the kitchen floor, staring at the ceiling, Claire’s fear still burning in her arm where the man had grabbed her.

Adam looked toward the wall they shared with apartment 4B.

For the first time since all of this began, Nora saw something like fear of the gift itself settle into his face.

Not fear for Nora.

Not only.

Fear of what Nora might be asked to do next.

Outside, the sirens came closer.

Inside, beneath Nora's skin, Claire's terror slowly loosened its grip.

But it did not leave.

None of them ever did.

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